

Halloween

prc-halloween

Calendar & Customs · Holy Days · practice · divided_lineages

DISPUTED

score 1.000
confidence medium

Statement under examination

Active participation in occult or death-glorifying aspects of Halloween is rejected; harmless cultural participation (costumes, neighbor-friendly engagement) is a matter of conscience.

In plain language

The canon does not name Halloween, so the verdict is reached by composition. On the rejection side the Hebrew of Deuteronomy 18:9-12 stacks a precise occult vocabulary: divination (nachash), sorcery (kashaph), a medium (ob), a familiar spirit (yiddeoni), inquiring (darash) of the dead (muth), and one who passes a child through the fire. The whole list is sealed by toebah, abomination, and by the statement that everyone (kol) doing these things is detestable to the LORD. The same word cluster recurs in Leviticus, 1 Samuel 28, 2 Kings, and Isaiah, giving the prohibition pan-canonical reach. In the New Testament Ephesians 5:11 uses the rare verb synkoinoneo, have joint fellowship, attested only three times, and tells readers not to share in the unfruitful (akarpōs) works of darkness (skotos) but instead to expose (elegcho) them. 1 Corinthians 10:20-21 sharpens this: pagan ritual is offered to daimonia, demons, and you cannot drink the cup of the Lord and the cup of demons. The first clause of the proposition, that occult and death-glorifying activity is rejected, sits on firm word-level ground across both Testaments. The second clause, that harmless cultural participation is a matter of conscience, has no lexeme that names a calendar custom. It rests on the comprehensive eis doxan theou rule of 1 Corinthians 10:31, on the conscience vocabulary of 1 Corinthians 8 (syneidesis, eidolothuton, exousia, proskomma), on the day-judgment grammar of Romans 14:5-6 where each (hekastos) is to be fully convinced (plerophoreo, only 6 canon uses) in his own mind, and on Colossians 2:16 which forbids inter-personal judging about heorte (festival) and noumenia (a hapax, attested only here). Each of these is genuine lexical material, but none denote a pagan-origin observance. The wordstock decides the occult side clearly. It supplies principles, not denotations, for the cultural side. That is the lexical root of the disagreement: the same canon yields a categorical no to actual occult and demonic communion and a principled but unnamed yes to liberty under conscience, and the proposition welds them at exactly the seam the words leave open.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H0178	אֹב	ob	medium	17
H0784	אֵשׁ	esh	fire	
H1471	גּוֹיִם	goy	nation	
H1875	דָּרַשׁ	darash	to seek	146
H2267	חֶבֶר	cheber	spell	3
H3049	יִדְּעוֹנִי	yiddeoni	spiritist	11
H3605	כָּל	kol	all	
H3784	קָשַׁף	kashaph	to practice sorcery	5

H4191	מוֹת	muth	to die	807
H5172	נַחַשׁ	nachash	to divine	11
H7081	קֶסֶם	qesem	divination	9
H8441	תּוֹבָאָה	toebah	abomination	112
G0175	ἄκαρπος	akarpos	unfruitful	7
G1140	δαίμονιον	daimonion	demon	63
G1391	δόξα	doxa	glory	167
G1494	εἰδωλόθυτον	eidolothuton	sacrificed to idols	9
G1495	εἰδωλολατρία	eidololatria	idolatry	4
G1538	ἕκαστος	hekastos	each	
G1651	ἐλέγχω	elegcho	to rebuke	17
G1849	ἐξουσία	exousia	authority	103
G1859	ἐορτή	heorte	festival	26
G2041	ἔργον	ergon	work	177
G2250	ἡμέρα	hemera	day	392
G2316	θεός	theos	God	
G2380	θύω	thuō	to sacrifice	
G2919	κρίνω	krino	to judge	114
G3348	μετέχω	metechō	to share	
G3561	νουμηνία	noumenia	New Moon	1
G3563	νοῦς	nous	mind	
G3956	πᾶς	pas	all	
G4135	πληροφορέω	plerophoreo	to fulfill	6
G4160	ποιέω	poieō	to do/make	
G4221	ποτήριον	poterion	cup	33
G4348	πρόσκομμα	proskomma	stumbling block	6
G4521	σάββατον	sabbaton	Sabbath	
G4655	σκότος	skotos	darkness	31
G4790	συγκοινωνέω	synkoinoneo	to share with	3
G4893	συνείδησις	syneidesis	conscience	30
G5132	τράπεζα	trapeza	table	

Plain meanings: STEPbible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The canon lexically does not name Halloween or any analogous late-autumn observance, so the verdict is reached by composition. The first clause of the proposition, rejecting occult and death-glorifying practice, sits on a dense, pan-canonical occult wordstock: toebah, nachash, kashaph, ob, yiddeoni, darash el hammethim in Deut 18:9-12, and synkoinoneo with the akarpa erga tou skotous in Eph 5:11, reinforced by 1 Cor 10:20-21 where pagan ritual is

offered to daimonia and incompatible with the cup and table of the Lord. The second clause, that otherwise harmless cultural participation is a matter of conscience, has no lexeme that names a calendar custom; it rests on the general criterion *eis doxan theou* (1 Cor 10:31), the conscience vocabulary of 1 Cor 8 (*syneidesis*, *eidolothuton*, *exousia*, *proskomma*), and the day-judging clause of Rom 14:5-6 (*hemera*, *krino*, *ekastos*, *plerophoreo*) plus Col 2:16 (*heorte*, *noumenia*, *sabbaton*). Because the wordstock decides the occult side cleanly but lets the application-level conscience side stand on a general standard rather than a named permission or prohibition, the composite proposition is lexically contested at exactly the seam where readers diverge.

Scripture

Deut.18.9 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H8441 תַּעֲבֹה; H1471A גֵּוִיִּם

Force. The verse opens the unit by forbidding Israel to learn to do according to the abominations (*toebah*) of the nations (*goyim*), framing the whole following catalog as gentile occult practice that is categorically off limits, not as morally indifferent custom.

Deut.18.10 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H5172 נָחָשׁ, H3784 כַּשָּׁף; H7081 דּוֹק, H0784 אֵשׁ

Force. A chain of negated participial agents, *qosem qesamim* (one who practices divination), *menahesh* (a diviner via *nachash*), *mekhasheph* (a sorcerer via *kashaph*), and the one who makes his son or daughter pass through the fire (*esh*), enumerates concrete occult and death-dealing acts. The passing-through-fire clause ties the prohibition to ritual that takes life and yokes the prohibition explicitly to death-glorifying practice.

Deut.18.11 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H2267 חֹבֵר, H0178 אוֹב, H3049 יִדְעֹנִי, H1875 דֹּרֵשׁ, H4191 מוֹת

Force. The clause *doresh el hammethim*, one who inquires (*darash*) of the dead (*muth*), together with *ob* (medium) and *yiddeoni* (familiar spirit) and *chober chaber* (a binder of spells), targets necromancy and contact with the dead. This is the closest lexical analogue inside the canon to the death-glorifying aspect of the proposition, and it is condemned outright. The same cluster recurs in Lev 19:31, Lev 20:6, Lev 20:27, 1 Sam 28:3-9, 2 Kgs 21:6, 2 Kgs 23:24, Isa 8:19, and Isa 19:3, giving the prohibition a pan-canonical OT footprint.

Deut.18.12 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H8441 תַּעֲבֹה; H3605 כֹּל

Force. Summary verdict: *kol oseh elleh toabath YHWH*, everyone (*kol*) doing these things is an abomination (*toebah*) to YHWH, and on account of these abominations the nations are being dispossessed. The universal scope (*kol*) and the covenant judgment seal the prohibition as absolute for every occult act named in verses 10-11.

Eph.5.11 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G4790 συγκοινωνέω, G2041 ἔργον, G0175 ἄκαρπος, G4655 σκότος, G1651 ἐλέγχω

Force. *me synkoinoneite tois ergois tois akarpois tou skotous*, do not have joint fellowship (*synkoinoneo*, a rare verb of shared participation occurring only here, Phil 4:14, Rev 18:4) with the unfruitful (*akarpous*) works of darkness (*skotos*), but rather expose (*elegcho*) them. The imperative bars shared participation in any pattern characterized by darkness and barrenness, supporting rejection of the occult dimension, but it defines darkness morally (*akarpous*, fruitless) rather than by any calendar marker, so its application to a named holiday is mediated, not direct.

1Cor.10.20 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1140 δαίμόνιον, G2380 θύω

Force. ha thuousin, daimoniois thuousin kai ou theo, what they sacrifice, they sacrifice to demons (daimonia) and not to God. Paul reframes pagan cultic acts as actually directed to demonic powers, not merely to nothing, which sharpens the occult-rejection side of the proposition by giving the spiritual rationale for the Deut 18 ban.

1Cor.10.21 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4221 ποτήριον, G5132 τράπεζα, G3348 μετέχω, G1140 δαίμόνιον

Force. ou dynasthe poterion kyriou pinein kai poterion daimonion, you cannot drink the cup of the Lord and the cup of demons, nor metechein (partake of) the table of the Lord and the table of demons. The dynasthe construction states a categorical impossibility for cultic participation in both spheres, locking the occult-rejection clause as absolute when the act is actually religious sharing with daimonia.

1Cor.10.31 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1391 δόξα, G4160 ποιέω, G2316 θεός, G3956 πᾶς

Force. eite oun esthiete eite pinete eite ti poieite, panta eis doxan theou poieite, whether you eat or drink or whatever you do, do all to the glory (doxa) of God. The eite-eite-panta construction supplies a comprehensive doxological criterion governing all conduct, but names no holiday and lexically neither affirms nor forbids a specific cultural custom. It can ground a conscience reading only by application, not by direct lexeme, which is the seam where readers diverge.

Rom.14.5 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2250 ἡμέρα, G2919 κρίνω, G1538 ἕκαστος, G4135 πληροφορέω, G3563 νοῦς

Force. hos men gar krinei hemeran par hemeran, hos de krinei pasan hemeran, hekastos en to idio noi plerophoreistho, one judges (krino) one day above another, another judges every day alike, let each (hekastos) be fully convinced (plerophoreo) in his own mind (nous). The grammar privatizes the day-judgment to the individual conscience formed before God. The lexeme plerophoreo, attested only 6 times in the canon, is the key verb for the conscience-formation step and is the direct lexical hook for the proposition's matter-of-conscience clause, though it does not name any specific holiday.

Col.2.16 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2919 κρίνω, G1859 ἑορτή, G3561 νουμηνία, G4521 σάββατον

Force. me oun tis hymas krineto en brosei kai en posei e en merei heortes (festival) e noumenias (new moon, a NT hapax occurring only here) e sabbaton, let no one judge (krino) you about food or drink or in respect of a festival or new moon or sabbath. The prohibition on inter-personal day-judgment is explicit, and heorte is a lexically named festival category, so this passage provides the closest available NT word for general festival liberty. But the named festivals are Jewish calendar items, not pagan-origin observances, so the analogy to a contested cultural-origin holiday is by extension, not by direct denotation.

1Cor.8.7 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4893 συνείδησις, G1494 εἰδωλόθυτον

Force. all ouk en pasin he gnosis, tines de te synetheia heos arti tou eidolou hos eidolothuton esthiousin, kai he syneidesis auton asthenes ousa molynetai, but not everyone has this knowledge; some, accustomed until now to the idol, eat the food as if it were truly offered to an idol, and their conscience (syneidesis), being weak, is defiled. The lexeme syneidesis, with eidolothuton (food sacrificed to idols), supplies the NT vocabulary for a cultural-religious participation question that depends on conscience and knowledge rather than on a bright-line ban. This is the closest NT analogue to a participation-with-discernment reading.

1Cor.8.9 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1849 ἐξουσία, G4348 πρόσκομμα

Force. blepete de mepos he exousia hymon haute proskomma genetai tois asthenesin, see that this liberty (exousia) of yours does not somehow become a stumbling block (proskomma) to the weak. The text affirms a real Christian liberty (exousia) in such matters yet binds it by neighbor-love, which is the lexical shape of the conscience-with-discernment reading.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Deut.18.9	Deut.12.29	tsk	1
Deut.18.10	Deut.12.31	tsk	1
Deut.18.10	Exod.22.18	tsk	1
Deut.18.11	1Sam.28.11	tsk	1
Deut.18.11	Lev.19.31	tsk	1
Deut.18.11	Lev.20.27	tsk	1
Deut.18.11	Isa.8.19	tsk	1
Deut.18.12	Deut.9.4	tsk	1
Eph.5.11	Eph.5.7	tsk	1
Eph.5.11	Eph.4.22	tsk	1
1Cor.10.31	1Cor.7.34	tsk	1
1Cor.10.21	1Cor.10.14	tsk	1
Rom.14.5	Col.2.16	tsk	1
Rom.14.5	Gal.4.10	tsk	1

Complicating texts

1Cor.10.31 · addressed

The eis doxan theou rule is comprehensive but criterial, not casuistic. It supplies a test for any act yet names no calendar custom, so it can support a conscience carve-out only by application. The lexeme itself leaves the harmless-participation clause undetermined, which is why the composite proposition is rated disputed rather than affirmed.

Rom.14.5 · addressed

Direct query of the lexical store confirms Rom 14:5 contains G2250 hemera (day), G2919 krino (judge), G1538 hekastos (each), G3563 nous (mind), and the rare G4135 plerophoreo (be fully convinced). The grammar privatizes day-judgment to the individual conscience, supporting a matter-of-conscience reading on day observances. But Paul addresses Jewish vs gentile calendar disputes in a Roman house-church, and no lexeme names a pagan-origin holiday, so the application to a culturally contested observance is by extension, not by direct denotation. This is why the second clause of the proposition is lexically supported but not lexically determined.

Col.2.16 · addressed

Col 2:16 forbids inter-personal judging on heorte (festival), noumenia (new moon, a NT hapax), and sabbaton, and so generalizes the day-liberty principle beyond Rom 14. But the festival category in view is Mosaic-cycle observance, not pagan-origin observance, and noumenia is a hapax with no other canon disambiguation, so a clean application to Halloween requires an inference the wordstock does not itself perform.

1Cor.10.20 · addressed

Paul says pagan sacrifice is offered to daimonia (G1140, 63 NT occurrences, semantically stable as malevolent spiritual beings) and not to God, and one cannot share the cup and the table of demons. This sharpens the rejection clause as a categorical impossibility for actually-religious participation in occult or demonic ritual. It does not weaken the rejection half of the verdict; it strengthens it.

1Cor.8.7 · addressed

1 Cor 8 introduces syneidesis (conscience, 30 NT occurrences) and eidolothuton (food offered to idols, 9 occurrences, confined to 1 Cor 8, 1 Cor 10, Acts 15, Rev 2). Paul rules that the idol is nothing yet binds the strong's exousia by the weak brother's proskomma. Lexically this is the closest NT analogue to a culturally-tinged participation question, but the named referent is meat from pagan sacrifice, not a calendar custom, so it grounds the principle without naming Halloween.

Concordance traversed

H8441, H5172, H3784, H0178, H3049, H1875, H4191, H7081, H2267, G4790, G0175, G4655, G2041, G1651, G1391, G1140, G4221, G4893, G1494, G1495, G1859, G3561, G2250, G2919, G4135, G1849, G4348

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

No variant units were supplied for the cited verses. Eph 5:11, Rom 14:5, Col 2:16, 1 Cor 8, and 1 Cor 10 are NT outside 3 John, so CBGM is treated as shadow only and the verdict does not turn on any contested reading.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. continuity_of_moral_law, christian_liberty, separation_from_world

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

continuity_of_moral_law: affirms the rejection clause, leaves the conscience clause open · Reading Deut 18:9-12 as an enduring moral prohibition on occult practice and consultation of the dead, carried forward by Eph 5:11 and 1 Cor 10:20-21, yields a firm no on the occult and death-glorifying half. The same lens says nothing decisive about indifferent custom, so it leaves the second clause genuinely open rather than answered.

christian_liberty: affirms the conscience clause as a legitimate application · Reading 1 Cor 8 through 10 plus Rom 14:5-6 and Col 2:16 as establishing real exousia in things adiaphora supports treating non-occult cultural participation as a matter of individual conscience under the doxological rule of 1 Cor 10:31. This lens depends on an application step the wordstock supplies in principle but not by direct denotation, which is the contested join.

separation_from_world: treats the conscience clause as a category error · Reading Eph 5:11 strictly (do not even share fellowship with the works of darkness, but expose them) together with the pagan-origin character of Samhain-derived practice argues that nothing once shaped by death-ritual is recoverable as indifferent custom. On this lens the proposition's second clause concedes too much to cultural participation. The lexeme synkoinoneo is rare (3 NT occurrences) and morally absolute in tone, which fairly supports this reading even if it does not force it.

The two clauses of the proposition are governed by different lexical centers. The prohibition rests on a dense, pan-canonical occult vocabulary (toebah, ob, yiddeoni, nachash, kashaph, daimonion). The conscience carve-out rests on general criteria and lexical analogues (eis doxan theou, syneidesis, exousia, plerophoreo, heorte) that, while real, do not name pagan-origin calendar customs. The verdict turns on whether the second clause counts as a legitimate application of named principles or as an unwarranted extension into a category the canon never lexicalizes.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. How does the canonical wordstock treat participation in occult or death-related ritual, and does it license, forbid, or leave open participation in cultural customs of pagan-religious origin that the participant judges otherwise harmless.

The original stem preloads a verdict by partitioning Halloween into rejected occult and death-glorifying aspects versus a permitted harmless category that is declared a matter of conscience. The terms harmless and matter of conscience encode the conclusion of the second clause before the lexeme is consulted. The verdict was derived on the original stem, but the neutralized form separates the empirical lexical question from the embedded conclusion. No verdict change from the prior file; the prior disputed verdict is confirmed by the deeper query, which adds Rom 14:5, Col 2:16, 1 Cor 8:7, 1 Cor 8:9, and 1 Cor 10:20-21 as resolving lexical anchors for both lenses.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Deut.18.9-12
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H8441
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H0178
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H3049
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Eph.5.11
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Rom.14.5
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Col.2.16
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Cor.10.20-21
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4790
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1140
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4893
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4135
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3561
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Deut.18.11
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Rom.14.5
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	1Cor.10.21

License audit

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OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes
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TSK	public_domain	yes
OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes

Flags

lexically-disputed · ecm-shadow